

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 4 OF 12

The Welcome

FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For the one who left, and for the one who waits by the door. May a door open, and may it stay open.



Father Lucas



BOOK 4

This book: The one who left, the one who doesn't call, the brother who stopped coming. How to open the door again, and keep it open.

How it goes: Week 1 prepares the place. Week 2 takes the first small step. Week 3 puts down pride. The last days make the call, face the silence, and light the way home.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

Days 92–122 · 31 mornings

Month psalm: 84 — "How lovely is your dwelling place." The psalm for anyone who misses home.

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

My friend,

You came through the quiet house, and now we turn to the chair at the table that has no one in it. This month is for the one who left, the one who doesn't call, the brother who stopped coming by.

I can't promise you a ringing phone. I have seen it ring, and I have seen it stay quiet. I can promise you something steadier: a place set, a name said out loud, a porch light on, and Mary walking the road ahead of you.

Thirty-one mornings. Three minutes each. Let's get the plate down from the shelf.

— Father Lucas

THE MONTH ON ONE PAGE

Days 92–98: Prepare the place. A chair, a name, a photograph, the first honest sentence, and the father who ran.

Days 99–105: Take the first small step. A postcard, a Day 100 candle, a text, a kind word, and a birthday remembered.

Days 106–112: Put down the pride. A locked gate, a porch light, a grandchild, a smaller ask, and a bed made up.

Days 113–122: Forgive first. Make the call, find peace with a sibling, face the silence, open the gate, and light the welcome candle.

THREE PROMISES FOR THIS MONTH

I will leave the porch light on, even when no one asks.

I will say their name out loud before I say anything about them.

I will reach out small, and I will not keep score.

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WEEK 1

Week 1

DAYS 92 TO 98

This week: Set a Place at the Table; The Silence After the Fight; Their Name, Your Breath; Mary Searched Three Days.



DAY 92

Set a Place at the Table



Turn us again, God. Cause your face to shine, and we will be saved.

PSALM 80:3 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. You've carried this one a long time, so we start small. We start with a plain old plate, the kind you eat off every day.

Somewhere there's a person you love who isn't sitting at your table. Maybe they left angry. Maybe they drifted, and nobody can say the day it happened. We won't fix it this morning. We'll make room. A place set for someone is a quiet kind of prayer. It says, "I haven't given away your chair."

Mary knows what an empty chair feels like. She won't mind that it's yours.

Mary, here's the chair nobody sits in. Here's the name I stopped saying out loud. I'm not asking you to fix them today. I'm asking you to keep this place with me. Don't let my heart close up around the empty spot. When I pass that plate, let me think of them kindly, and let my hands stay gentle with the dishes. Amen.



TODAY

Set one extra place at your table, a plate and a fork, even if no one is coming. Leave it there until you finish your coffee.

☐ DONE

Whose empty chair have I stopped looking at on purpose?

PSALM

80 — "Turn us again": the oldest prayer for people who have drifted from home.



DAY 93

The Silence After the Fight

Keep your tongue from evil, and your lips from speaking lies. Depart from evil, and do good. Seek peace, and pursue it.

PSALM 34:13-14 (WEB)

Maybe it was a phone call that ended too fast. Maybe a dinner that ended with a slammed door. It's been quiet since, and you replay the last words the way you press on a bruise.

You know what you said. You know what they said, too. A silence after a fight has weight, and it gets heavier the longer it sits. You don't have to break it today. You only have to stop feeding it.

So give it a name. Three words, the shortest and truest you have. Mary can work with three honest words better than with three hundred polished ones.

Lord Jesus, you heard sharp words in your own house, and you stayed kind. I'm sorry for my part, even the part I can't see yet. Soften what's hard in me. Quiet the replay in my head, and let the last thing said between us not be the last thing said. Keep me from calling it fine when it isn't. Amen.



TODAY

Write three words for how you feel about the last time you spoke. Cross out the heaviest one, and take a slow breath.

☐ DONE

What do I most want them to know that I never said?

PSALM

81 — God longs for his people to listen; the psalm for a quarrel that has gone quiet.



DAY 94

Their Name, Your Breath

But now the LORD who created you, Jacob, and he who formed you, Israel, says: "Don't be afraid, for I have redeemed you. I have called you by your name. You are mine.

ISAIAH 43:1 (WEB)

Tom lives next door to me, and he lives alone. Years ago he told me he says his son's name into the kitchen sink every morning, just to keep it from rusting. I didn't laugh. I understood him.

A name you won't say goes stiff, like a gate nobody opens. Today, say it. Not to argue. Not to the person. Just out loud, in your own house, on your own breath.

God has called each of us by name, and he never lost yours or theirs. Say it slowly. Let it be a prayer all by itself.

Our Lady, here's their name. I say it with no speech and no complaint. You know the face that goes with it. You know the child, or the brother, or the friend I remember. Keep that name safe in your hands today. I'll keep it in my mouth. When the day gets loud, bring it back to me. Amen.



TODAY

Say the names of your family in order of age, slowly. When you reach theirs, stop, breathe in, and say it twice.

☐ DONE

When did I last say their name without flinching?

PSALM

84 — a psalm for anyone who misses home; he keeps a place for every one of us.



DAY 95

Mary Searched Three Days

but supposing him to be in the company, they went a day's journey; and they looked for him among their relatives and acquaintances. When they didn't find him, they returned to Jerusalem, looking for him.

LUKE 2:44-45 (WEB)

You may have thought, "I shouldn't worry this much." Listen. Mary worried. The Gospel doesn't hide it. She and Joseph asked among every relative and neighbor, and when they found nothing, they walked all the way back to Jerusalem, looking.

She didn't scold herself for being afraid. She didn't wait by the door for someone else to bring him. She walked back along the road. That's what a mother's love looks like when it can't do anything but look.

Whoever you're looking for, you're not foolish. You're doing what she did. And she knows the road.

Mary, you walked the road and asked in every doorway. Walk it ahead of me today. I can't see where they are, but you can. Be near them in any room they enter. Be near me in this kitchen, where I'm looking at a photograph and trying to be brave. Keep me from giving up on the road. Amen.



TODAY

Look at a photograph of them and say today's prayer once more, aloud and slowly, as if they could hear you.

☐ DONE

Where have I been searching that might not be where they are?

PSALM

106 — the Lord remembers his people; he is the one who never stops looking.



DAY 96

What You Would Say First



So, then, my beloved brothers, let every man be swift to hear, slow to speak, and slow to anger;

JAMES 1:19 (WEB)

You've rehearsed it in the shower. You've rehearsed it in the car. Every version starts with a point you want to win, and every version ends with a door closing again.

The first sentence matters more than the next ten. People hear the first few words with their whole body, the way you hear a knock at night. If those words are "you were wrong," they brace. If they're "I miss you," something in them may unclench.

So don't write the speech. Find the first line, and make it short enough to say with a shaky voice.

Father, I have so many words and so little sense about which to use. Take the speeches out of my mouth. Leave me one honest sentence. Let me say it kindly, and let me listen after. If they say nothing, help me stand there anyway, and keep my voice from shaking too much. Stay in the room with me. Amen.



TODAY

Write one sentence that begins, "The first thing I'd say is..." Then cut it down to six words or fewer.

☐ DONE

Would I rather be right today, or be reached?

PSALM

107 — "Let the redeemed of the LORD say so": the psalm for people brought home.

97

DAY 97

Don't Wait for Sorry

But God commends his own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

ROMANS 5:8 (WEB)

Walt, our retired usher, once told me he waited so long for an apology that he forgot what it was for. He only knew he was owed one. That's a lonely way to live. It's like sitting up for a train on a track that's been torn up.

Maybe the apology will come. Maybe it won't, or it'll come in a form you don't recognize. Either way, your heart can't wait on a schedule it doesn't control.

God didn't wait for us to be sorry first. You don't have to be better than that. You only have to be a little less tired.

Lord, I've been keeping score, and I'm tired of the arithmetic. I'm putting the ledger down, just for today. Whatever they owe me, you can hold it for me. Teach me to be the one who steps toward the road. Make my arms a little lighter than they were last night, and my chest, too. Amen.



TODAY

Decide you won't keep score until nine tomorrow morning. Say it out loud once at the sink: "Not until nine."

☐ DONE

Whose apology am I still waiting for, and for how long?

PSALM

126 — "Those who sow in tears will reap with songs of joy"; patience that isn't bitter.

98

DAY 98

The Father Who Ran

He arose and came to his father. But while he was still far off, his father saw him and was moved with compassion, and ran, fell on his neck, and kissed him.

LUKE 15:20 (WEB)

You know the story. The younger son took the money and left, spent it, and came home with a speech in his pocket. But look at what the father is doing. He isn't inside. He's watching the road. He sees his son while he's still far off.

And then he runs. Old men didn't run. He did. He didn't wait for the speech, and he didn't ask for receipts.

I think he'd been looking at that road every day. That's the whole prayer for today. Keep looking at the road, and don't be ashamed that you do.

Father, I'm the one watching the road. Some mornings I'm brave about it, and some mornings I just feel foolish. Give me your patience, and give me your legs. If they come, let me run. If they don't, let me keep my eyes kind. Mary, stand by me at the door. Hold my elbow when my knees go weak. Amen.



TODAY

Sit in your favorite chair until the clock has moved five minutes. Face the door. In your mind, watch the road.

☐ DONE

What would I do in the first ten seconds if they appeared?

PSALM

133 — "How good it is when brothers live together": the picture at the end of the road.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A knot you've loosened can tie again, and it happens quietly: a week without the page, and the road looks emptier than it is. The father kept looking. Open tomorrow's page.



WEEK 2

Week 2

DAYS 99 TO 105

This week: A Postcard Without a Reason; A Hundred Mornings; Photos on the Shelf; A Text You Haven't Sent.



DAY 99

A Postcard Without a Reason

Like cold water to a thirsty soul, so is good news from a far country.

PROVERBS 25:25 (WEB)

A postcard has no room for a lecture. That's why I love it. A picture on one side, a few lines on the other, a small stamp.

When a person has been away from you, a long letter can feel like a trap. So does "We need to talk." But "I saw a barn like the one on your grandfather's farm" is only a hello. It asks for nothing.

Good news from far away is cold water to a thirsty soul. Be a little cold water. Don't write a reason. The reason is that you love them.

Mary, I'm afraid a few lines won't be enough. I'm afraid they'll be too much. Guide my pen. Keep out the old complaint and the little hook. Let these words be light enough to carry across the miles, and kind enough to be read. I'll leave the rest with you, and I'll try not to hover over the mailbox. Amen.



TODAY

Write two lines on a card for someone far away. Say only that you thought of them. Decide tomorrow whether to mail it.

☐ DONE

What small, ordinary thing reminds me of them this week?

PSALM

40 — "I waited patiently": he turns, he hears, and the waiting is not wasted.



DAY 100

A Hundred Mornings

It is a good thing to give thanks to the LORD, to sing praises to your name, Most High, to proclaim your loving kindness in the morning, and your faithfulness every night,

PSALM 92:1-2 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. This is Day 100. A hundred mornings with the page, the coffee, and the prayer. Most people quit long before this. You didn't.

Look back a minute. I won't tell you what should have changed. Maybe you set a place at the table. Maybe a name is softer in your mouth. Maybe a stamped card is sitting by the phone, not mailed yet. Maybe nothing has moved, and that's honest, too.

A hundred mornings of showing up makes a road. You're still on it, and so is she.

Our Lady, a hundred mornings. I didn't think I'd last. Thank you for every one, including the ones I did badly. Keep me on this road when the days feel the same and I'm tempted to quit. Whatever has loosened, let it stay loose. Whatever hasn't moved yet, I give to you again, with open hands. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle for one name on your Names Page and say it aloud. Then say, "A hundred mornings. I'm still here."

☐ DONE

What has changed in me, even a little, since Day 1?

PSALM

60 — "Give us help against the trouble": a psalm for the stretch of road that feels long.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The same tide that tied the knot is still out there. A hundred mornings isn't the end of the tide. It's a good long stretch of beach. Stay on it, and keep your feet in the sand.



DAY 101

Photos on the Shelf

The LORD looks from heaven.
He sees all the sons of men.
From the place of his
habitation he looks out on all
the inhabitants of the earth,

PSALM 33:13-14 (WEB)

Some of us turned the picture to face the wall. Some of us took it off the shelf the year it got bad and tucked it in a box. I'm not scolding anybody. A picture can hurt like a pebble in a shoe.

But when we hide a face, we start telling ourselves they're gone. They're not gone. They're far away, and that's a different thing, and a mother's prayer can cross it.

Bring one photograph out into the light. Pick the one where they're laughing, or where they're small. Stand it where you'll see it when you pass.

Holy Mother, I've kept their face in a box because it hurt to look. Today I'm standing it where I can see it. Let me look at it without bitterness. Let me remember the good years as true years. And when I walk past with the laundry or the keys, let me whisper, "God keep you." Amen.



TODAY

Move one photograph of them to where your eyes land first when you walk into the kitchen. Dust the frame with your sleeve.

☐ DONE

Which picture did I hide, and what was I afraid it would say?

PSALM

61 — "From the end of the earth I call": the psalm for someone far away.

102

DAY 102

A Text You Haven't Sent

Pleasant words are a honeycomb, sweet to the soul, and health to the bones.

PROVERBS 16:24 (WEB)

You wrote it six times. You erased it six times. The phone sits face down on the counter like a hot pan.

Patricia and Dale did that for a week with their son. Every night they typed something, and one of them said, "Too much," and erased it. On the eighth day they sent three words about a bird at the feeder. Nothing came back for a long while. Then one word did, and Patricia cried at the sink.

I can't promise a word back. I can tell you a small kind message is never wasted. It doesn't have to be wise. It has to be short.

Lord Jesus, my thumb is shaking over this little glass screen. Take the fear of being ignored, and take the fear of being answered. Let me send something small and true, and then let me put the phone down. Don't let me check it every minute. Keep me busy with the dishes, and keep me in your hands. Amen.



TODAY

Send one short text with no question in it, like "Saw a cardinal at the feeder and thought of you." Then put the phone in another room.

☐ DONE

What is the smallest true thing I could say to them?

PSALM

80 — "Cause your face to shine": a face turned toward us first, so we can turn toward theirs.



DAY 103

Speak Their Good

> *Joy comes to a man with the reply of his mouth. How good is a word at the right time!*
>
> PROVERBS 15:23 (WEB)

We tell the story of what went wrong so often that it wears a groove. You can recite it in your sleep. The date, the words, the look on the face.

But there's another story, and you've nearly forgotten it. The boy who hummed in the back seat. The girl who always took the last cookie and left the crumbs for you to find. The way they laughed when they thought nobody was watching.

Tell that story out loud today, to an empty kitchen. It isn't pretending. It's the other half of the truth, and your heart needs to hear it in your own voice.

Mary, I've told the sad story so many times I forgot the happy one. Open my memory like a window in a kitchen. Let me say the good things about them, and mean every word. Wherever they are, let a little of that goodness find its way back to them. Hold it for me tonight. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud three good things about them, as if they were sitting across the table from you.

☐ DONE

Which good memory of them did I stop telling myself?

PSALM

81 — "I would feed you with the finest of the wheat": God remembers the good in us too.



DAY 104

Their Side of the Story

He who pleads his cause first seems right— until another comes and questions him.

PROVERBS 18:17 (WEB)

I'm going to ask something hard this morning, and I'll be gentle about it. Have you ever tried telling the story the way they'd tell it?

You may not agree. You may think they'd get half of it wrong. That's all right. We're not giving up your side. We're walking around the house to see what it looks like from their yard.

I did this once. My brother remembered the same evening differently. I was sure I was right. He was sure, too. The truth had room for both of us.

Lord, give me the courage to look through their window for a moment. Don't let me lose my own footing. Let me see just one thing I missed. Soften the part of me that has to win. Let me listen as if I were hearing it for the first time, and let me stay kind to myself while I do. Be near them, too. Amen.



TODAY

Write three sentences telling the last fight from their side, the way they'd tell it. You don't have to agree. Just write it down on paper.

☐ DONE

What might they have been afraid of that day?

PSALM

84 — "How lovely is your dwelling place": a house with room for every version of the story.



DAY 105

The Birthday You Remember

Can a woman forget her nursing child, that she should not have compassion on the son of her womb? Yes, these may forget, yet I will not forget you!

ISAIAH 49:15 (WEB)

Your body knows the date before your head does. A little dip in the chest, an odd hush in the afternoon, and then you realize. It's their birthday.

You remember the weight of them in your arms. The cake that leaned. The candle that wouldn't stay lit. And now no card, no call.

That date isn't yours alone. God remembers it too, with more love than you do. If you can't send anything today, write the date on your Names Page in small letters and let the Lord keep it with you.

Father, I remember the day they were born. I remember the first sound. You were there before I was, and you're there now. Whatever the day is for them this year, let it be a soft one. Let someone be kind to them. And let me carry this date without letting it crush me. Amen.



TODAY

On your Names Page, write their birthday in small letters beside their name. Then say a Hail Mary for their year ahead.

☐ DONE

What do I most want for them on the day they were born?

PSALM

106 — "He remembered for them his covenant": the Lord keeps the dates we think are lost.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Somebody on your Names Page is counting on you this morning, whether they know it or not. If you skip the prayer, the name just waits. Don't let it wait alone.



WEEK 3

Week 3

DAYS 106 TO 112

This week: Pride Is a Locked Gate; Light the Porch; The Grandchild You Rarely See; Pray for Their Road.



DAY 106

Pride Is a Locked Gate

But he gives more grace. Therefore it says, "God resists the proud, but gives grace to the humble."

JAMES 4:6 (WEB)

I've kept a gate locked, my friend. For longer than I like to say, I told myself it was for protection, and some of it was. But a gate locked from the inside keeps you in as well as them out.

Pride is a clever guard. It says, "They should come first." It says, "I did nothing wrong." Sometimes it's even right. It never asks if you're lonely.

You don't have to throw the gate open this morning. Just find the bolt, and look at it. Then pick one small thing that stands for the old grudge, and put it where you can't see it.

Lord, I'm proud in places I haven't named. I've called it self-respect, and some of it is. Show me which part is the bolt. Don't make me crawl. Just make me a little lighter, so I can lift my own hand to the latch when the time comes. Stay beside me while I find it. Amen.



TODAY

Find a small thing that stands for the grudge, like a receipt or an old card. Put it in a box and close the lid.

☐ DONE

What am I protecting by keeping this gate locked?

PSALM

131 — a humble heart that has quieted itself, like a child on its mother's lap.



DAY 107

Light the Porch

Then they are glad because it is calm, so he brings them to their desired haven.

PSALM 107:30 (WEB)

When I was a boy, my grandfather left the porch light on until the last person was home. We could be out late, and wherever we were, we could see it from the end of the road. We knew somebody was waiting up.

A porch light says, "You're expected." It doesn't say, "You owe me an explanation." It doesn't say anything, really. It just burns.

Today we turn one on, in daylight, with nobody there to see. It's a small, silly thing, and I want you to do it anyway. A light is a prayer without words.

Mary, I'm lighting this lamp for someone who might be walking in the dark. I don't know where they are tonight. You do. Show them the way back to a lit door, and show them the door isn't closed and a warm kitchen is waiting. Keep the lamp burning in me, too, when I get tired of hoping. Amen.



TODAY

Turn on the porch light, or the lamp by your front door, in daylight. Leave it on until you finish your coffee, and say their name once.

☐ DONE

If they saw a light at my door, what would it tell them?

PSALM

107 — "He brings them to their desired haven": the psalm for everyone who is on the way home.



DAY 108

The Grandchild You Rarely See

Children's children are the crown of old men; the glory of children is their parents.

PROVERBS 17:6 (WEB)

You remember them at six, with a missing tooth and a loud voice. Now they're a stranger's height, and you hear about them secondhand. A photograph here. A short text there. The distance isn't their fault.

Whatever stands between you and their parent, the child didn't build it. A grandchild is a door of their own. Your voice on a quiet message can be the one warm thing in a loud week.

So don't ask anything. Don't mention the quarrel. Just be the voice that says, "I was thinking of you." Then let it be enough.

Gentle Mother, there's a young person out there who carries my blood and half my stubbornness. I don't know what they think of me. Let them know they're loved, without a speech from me. Walk beside them wherever they go today, and keep me from trying too hard. And let me be steady, so if they ever look for me, I'm here, easy to find, with the door unlatched. Amen.



TODAY

Leave a voicemail for your grandchild, or their parent, that says only, "I was thinking of you." No questions, no news.

☐ DONE

What would I want them to remember about me?

PSALM

128 — "May you see your children's children": a blessing for a long family table.



DAY 109

Pray for Their Road



If I take the wings of the dawn, and settle in the uttermost parts of the sea, even there your hand will lead me, and your right hand will hold me.

PSALM 139:9-10 (WEB)

Whatever road they're on today, you can't walk it for them. You can't drive behind them, or check their locks, or fill their gas tank. That's a hard thing to learn, and some of us learn it slowly.

But you can pray for the road. For the stoplight that turns in time. For the person at the next desk who says something kind. For the stranger who holds a door. Prayer goes places a worried parent can't.

The psalm says even at the far edge of the sea, the Lord's hand leads. So their road is already held.

Mary, I give you their road today. The left turns and the long hallways. The hour they're tired and the hour they're alone. Put one good person near them. Put one good thought in them. Let nothing I say or fail to say stand in the way of their safe arrival. And let me rest a little while you walk ahead. Amen.



TODAY

Step to your front door. Say aloud, "Mary, walk the road ahead of them today." Then close the door gently.

☐ DONE

Where do I picture them most when I worry?

PSALM

139 — "Even there your hand will lead me": no distance is beyond his reach.



DAY 110

A Smaller Ask



For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light.

MATTHEW 11:30 (WEB)

Here's something I've noticed about the way we hope. We hope for the whole thing at once. That they'll come home, say sorry, sit down, and eat what we cooked. It's a big ask. Maybe that's why the hope feels so heavy.

Try a smaller one. Ask for a hello. Ask for the time of day. Ask for a "fine, thanks" on the other end of a line. A hello is easy to say, and easy to try again.

Small asks keep the road open. They ask for less than the whole homecoming, and they leave room for more. Nobody ever slammed a door on a hello.

Lord, I'm tired of asking for everything. Teach me to ask for less. A hello. A gentle word. Ten minutes of ordinary talk. Let me take whatever small thing comes as a gift, not a debt. And let me stay thankful even when it's less than I hoped, even when it's nothing at all today. Amen.



TODAY

Call one person you've lost touch with and ask only, "How are you, really?" Make no other request. End kindly, and don't stay on too long.

☐ DONE

What is the smallest thing I could ask of them today?

PSALM

133 — "How good and pleasant": small, ordinary unity is already a kind of blessing.



DAY 111

Letters Never Sent

I cry with my voice to the LORD. With my voice, I ask the LORD for mercy. I pour out my complaint before him. I tell him my troubles.

PSALM 142:1-2 (WEB)

Some of us have a letter in us that has grown for years. Long and angry, or long and sad, or long and sorry. Most of it will never be mailed, and it shouldn't be.

But it has to go somewhere. A thing that's never written down stays in the chest and presses on the ribs.

So write it all the way to the end. Every unfair, tender, ugly, true thing. Then tuck it away and let God read it first. If you ever want a human reader, Sister Camille reads what people send her.

Father, here's the letter I carry. Everything I never said is on this page. Read it before anyone, and be gentle with the ugly parts. Keep the hard parts from poisoning me, and keep the soft parts safe. When I'm done, let my hands unclench, and let my shoulders come down. I trust you with every line, and with them. Amen.



TODAY

Write the letter you'll never send, all the way to the end. Fold it once and slip it inside your Bible.

☐ DONE

Which sentence in that letter surprised me when I wrote it?

PSALM

40 — "He heard my cry": the Lord reads the letters we can't mail.



DAY 112

Make the Bed in Their Room



In my Father's house are many homes. If it weren't so, I would have told you. I am going to prepare a place for you.

JOHN 14:2 (WEB)

It may be a room at the end of the hall. It may be the pullout couch. It may be a corner of the house you called theirs. You haven't touched it in a long time, because touching it meant admitting they might not sleep there again.

Today, go in. Straighten the quilt. Plump the pillow. Put a folded towel at the foot of the bed.

You're not saying they're coming. You're saying that if they do, there's a place. Jesus said he's preparing a place for us. You can do a small version of that with your own hands.

Lord Jesus, you went to prepare a place for me. I can't prepare a heaven, but I can fold a towel. Bless this bed and this room. Let it be a place of rest if someone comes. Let it be a place of peace if no one does. And let the love in these hands go wherever they are. Amen.



TODAY

Make up one bed in your house as if they were arriving tonight. Straighten the quilt and fold a towel at the foot.

☐ DONE

What would I hope they feel the moment they walked in?

PSALM

60 — a psalm for lost ground: the Lord can restore even a room you stopped entering.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I let it slip once. I stopped looking at the road for a long while, and the knot tightened without a sound. Don't do what I did. Come back tomorrow, tired or not.



WEEK 4

Week 4

DAYS 113 TO 122

This week: Forgive Before They Ask; What You Won't Say Again; Hands That Wait; The First Phone Call.



DAY 113

Forgive Before They Ask

bearing with one another, and forgiving each other, if any man has a complaint against any; even as Christ forgave you, so you also do.

COLOSSIANS 3:13 (WEB)

This is the hard door. Forgive before they ask. Before they say sorry. Before they even know you've been carrying it.

I'll tell you what it isn't. It isn't saying it didn't hurt. It isn't a handshake, or a reunion, or a promise to forget. You can forgive someone and still keep the door on its chain for a while.

What it is: setting down a bag you've been dragging up the stairs. You've been carrying their share. Today you leave it on the landing. You don't have to feel warm about it. You only have to open your hands.

Jesus, you forgave while the nails were still going in, and I can barely forgive across a kitchen table. I'm not ready, but I'm willing to be made ready. Take the part of this that's too heavy for me. Do the forgiving where I can't, and I'll do the little bit I can. Hold me steady. Amen.



TODAY

Drop your shoulders, loosen your jaw, and open your hands. Notice which one was tightest. Breathe out slowly and let that one go.

☐ DONE

What would my body feel like if I weren't carrying this?

PSALM

51 — "Create in me a clean heart": the heart that can forgive begins with a clean one.



DAY 114

What You Won't Say Again

a time to tear, and a time to sew; a time to keep silence, and a time to speak;

ECCLESIASTES 3:7 (WEB)

Every house has its old lines. "After all I've done for you." "You never call." "You're just like your father." They come up so fast they hardly pass through the mind. They live on the tongue.

I have a few of my own, and I'm not proud of them. Each one still lies in the road between me and someone I love.

Today, don't say them. Not even in your head. When one rises, let it pass like a truck on the highway. There's a time to speak, the Bible says. There's also a time to keep quiet.

Lord, guard my mouth like a door. When the old line comes up, let me breathe instead. Show me which words I'd regret by supper. Give me the strength of silence, which isn't weakness. And when it's time to speak again, give me better words than the ones I wore out. Make them short, make them kind, and make them true. Amen.



TODAY

Keep the TV and the radio off until noon. When the old speech rises, let it pass like a truck, and say nothing.

☐ DONE

Which old line do I most want to retire?

PSALM

61 — "I will abide in your tent forever": a place where no old speeches are needed.

115

DAY 115

Hands That Wait

but those who wait for the LORD will renew their strength. They will mount up with wings like eagles. They will run, and not be weary. They will walk, and not faint.

ISAIAH 40:31 (WEB)

We think waiting is doing nothing. It isn't. Anyone who has waited at a bus stop in the cold, or for one phone call, knows it takes all of you.

Watch what your hands do while you wait. They wring a dish towel. They flip the phone over and over. They straighten the same corner of the counter three times. That's a nervous kind of prayer.

Today we give them a different job. Open them. Lay them on your lap, palms up, the way you'd hold a bowl. Let them be empty for a minute. That's what waiting looks like when it's faith.

Mary, my hands are tired of gripping. They've held this worry like a hot cup all week. Take it from me. Fill these open hands with whatever you think best, even if it's only quiet. Teach me to wait without clenching, and to be ready without hovering over the window. I'll hold still and let you fill them. Amen.



TODAY

Hold your coffee cup in both hands for a moment. Then set it down and rest your empty hands, palms up, on your lap for one minute.

☐ DONE

What do my hands do when I'm worried about them?

PSALM

80 — "Restore us": the psalm for a people who wait with open hands.



DAY 116

The First Phone Call



Haven't I commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Don't be afraid. Don't be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.

JOSHUA 1:9 (WEB)

Your heart is pounding and you haven't even picked up the phone. That's normal. Nobody calls the person they've been apart from without a little shaking in the knees.

Today isn't about the right words. Words are for later. Today is about courage, and courage is just doing the next small thing while afraid. Find the name. Look at it. Breathe.

If you can press the button, press it. If you can't, scroll to the name and sit with it. That counts too. Take a week if you must. She'll wait with you.

Mary, go with me to the phone. My finger is cold and my mouth is dry. If they answer, give me a calm voice and a short sentence. If they don't, give me peace about the quiet. Whatever happens, I want to have tried today. Stay in the room until I'm done, and stay after, too. Amen.



TODAY

Find their number on your phone. Hold it there for one slow breath, say, "Mary, go with me," and press call if you can.

☐ DONE

What's the worst that could happen, and could I live through it?

PSALM

81 — "Open your mouth wide": the courage to speak first.



DAY 117

The Friend Who Drifted



A friend loves at all times; and a brother is born for adversity.

PROVERBS 17:17 (WEB)

Not every lost person is a child or a sibling. Sometimes it's a friend. The woman you used to sit beside in the pew. The man who fixed your gutter and stayed for pie. You didn't fight. You just stopped. A move, a funeral, a long illness, and the weeks turned into years.

Now it feels too late, and awkward, and silly. But friendship doesn't expire like milk. It sits in the pantry and waits.

You'd be surprised how many people are sitting beside a phone hoping an old friend will call. They think what you think. Be the one who goes first.

Lord, thank you for the friends I let drift. Forgive me for the cards I never sent and the calls I put off. Give me the nerve to say hello after so long. Warm their heart when it arrives. Give us something simple to talk about, like the weather, and let that be enough for the first time. Amen.



TODAY

Text a friend you've drifted from a photo of something from your morning. Add no question and no explanation, not even "long time."

☐ DONE

Who sat beside me once and now sits far away?

PSALM

84 — "Blessed are those who dwell in your house": the house is bigger than the family.



DAY 118

Peace With a Sibling

Esau ran to meet him, embraced him, fell on his neck, kissed him, and they wept.

GENESIS 33:4 (WEB)

I forgot to call my sister for a year. It wasn't a fight. Each of us just waited for the other, and the waiting grew its own walls.

When I finally dialed, her voice was so like our mother's that I couldn't speak for a moment. She said, "Lucas?" and we both laughed and cried at once. I've been ashamed ever since that I waited so long.

Siblings share a childhood nobody else remembers. That outlasts every quarrel. Esau ran to meet his brother, and they wept. The old hurt gave way in a single embrace.

Mary, you know family from the inside. Here are the ones who grew up under my parents' roof, spoken aloud. Soften the stubborn child in me and in them. Remind us of the backyard and the shared bedroom and the way we split the last slice of pie. Let us be, again, people who come from the same kitchen. Amen.



TODAY

Read three names aloud from your Names Page, including a brother or sister if you have one, and say one sentence of prayer for each.

☐ DONE

What was the last good thing we shared as children?

PSALM

106 — "He remembered his covenant": brothers and sisters are never fully lost to him.



DAY 119

When They Do Not Answer

But as for me, I will look to the LORD. I will wait for the God of my salvation. My God will hear me.

MICAH 7:7 (WEB)

You called, and it rang until it stopped. Or you wrote, and no reply came, and the days piled up. Now your imagination is busy. It says they're angry. It says they read it and rolled their eyes. It says you'll never try again.

Stop. A silence isn't a verdict. They may be busy, or afraid, or ashamed. They may need more time than you do. They may have simply lost the phone.

Your part was to reach out. You did that. The answer isn't yours to carry. Put the phone in the next room, and don't check it for an hour.

Lord, I reached out, and the quiet came back. It hurts. I won't pretend it doesn't. But I trust you to carry the part I can't. Hold them tonight. Keep my mind from writing the worst story. Keep my hands busy and my heart open, and let me wait without turning bitter. Let me sleep tonight. Amen.



TODAY

Look out a window for one full minute with your phone in another room. Watch whatever is moving out there.

☐ DONE

What can I let go of that was never mine to carry?

PSALM

107 — "They cried to the LORD in their trouble": the cry is always heard, even when the answer is slow.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

What you skip for a day, you skip for two. If the phone stayed quiet, come back to the small thing tomorrow, without guilt. That's how a thread stays loose in your hands.



DAY 120

Open the Gate Wider

Lift up your heads, you gates! Be lifted up, you everlasting doors, and the King of glory will come in.

PSALM 24:7 (WEB)

Some gates open a crack, just wide enough for a person to slip through. That's a good start.

But maybe it's time for a wider one. A gate you could drive a wagon through. One that lets the son walk in with a suitcase in each hand, or the daughter with three children trailing behind. A gate that says, "All of you. Just as you are."

It may feel risky. Here's the risk: you'll be disappointed. Here's the other risk: you won't be. Open it wide, and let God stand in the gap.

Holy Mother, I've kept my gate open only a little. Today I want to open it wide. Give me the courage to leave it that way, even when it brings wind and noise and people I haven't planned for. Fill my house with whoever you send. Keep me from counting the cost, and keep me from locking up again when the house gets loud. Amen.



TODAY

Stand at your front door, open it, and spread both arms wide for ten seconds, as if opening a gate. Then close it gently.

☐ DONE

What would "all of you, just as you are" look like in my house?

PSALM

126 — "The LORD has done great things for us": the joy of a full table.



DAY 121

Coming Home Is a Long Walk



Blessed are those whose strength is in you, who have set their hearts on a pilgrimage.

PSALM 84:5 (WEB)

We picture coming home as one big moment. The door opens, the arms open, the dog barks, the kettle goes on. But the son in the story walked a long road to get there, mile by mile, with an empty stomach.

Coming home takes steps. A letter. A message. A few careful visits. Maybe a long silence in the middle and a careful sentence at the end. It won't always be tidy. The people you love may need to go slowly, and so may you.

So today we walk. Not far. Around the block, with a Hail Mary at each corner.

Mary, I want a quick ending to this story, and you know it. Teach me to walk slowly. Teach me to love the ordinary steps. Let me say a Hail Mary at each corner and believe each one counts. Whoever is walking toward me, or away, I place on your road. Keep my knees steady, and my heart from running ahead of my feet. Amen.



TODAY

Walk once around the block and say one Hail Mary at each corner. Walk slowly. Let your breath catch up.

☐ DONE

What's the next step I can take, not the last one?

PSALM

133 — "How good and pleasant": the end of the walk, where brothers sit down together.



DAY 122

The Welcome Candle

He has put a new song in my mouth, even praise to our God. Many shall see it, and fear, and shall trust in the LORD.

PSALM 40:3 (WEB)

This is the last morning of the book, and I want you to see how far you've come. You set a place at the table. You said a name aloud. You wrote three words, and a postcard, and maybe a letter you'll never mail. You turned on a light. You opened a gate.

We close this month with a candle. Not a candle of wishes, but one of welcome. It says, "The door is open. The table is ready. The love is real." It doesn't order anyone to come.

Whoever comes, or doesn't, a house made ready for love is a different house.

Our Lady, I light this candle for everyone who has gone from my table. For the one who left angry, the one who drifted, and the one who never said goodbye. May this light be a small sign that they're welcome. Let them feel it, wherever they are. Keep it burning in me when it's out on the table. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle by your front door or on your table. Say each name on your Names Page aloud, then blow it out with an "Amen."

☐ DONE

Who will I welcome first, in my heart, when the door opens?

PSALM

40 — "He has put a new song in my mouth": the song that follows a long wait.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A knot you've untied can be tied again. A door you keep open can be kept open. Check the latch each morning, and make sure you haven't quietly pulled it shut again.

BOOK 4 · CLOSING THE MONTH

LOOKING BACK

☐ Whose name did I say out loud this month that I hadn't said in a long time?

☐ What small thing did I do that felt too small, and wasn't?

☐ What did I forgive, even a little, before anyone asked?

☐ Is the porch light in my heart off, dim, or on this morning?

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

My friend,

You walked the long road home this month, and you walked it from your own kitchen. That takes more courage than most people know. Maybe the phone rang. Maybe it didn't. I won't ask you to count.

I'll ask you this instead. Did you keep the light on? A knot you have untied can be tied again, and the same tide that tied it is still out there. So keep the light on. Keep the name in your mouth. Keep opening the page.

Mary has not stopped walking that road. Neither have I.

— Father Lucas

THE SEAL OF THE MONTH

BOOK 4 · THE LONG ROAD HOME

Date:

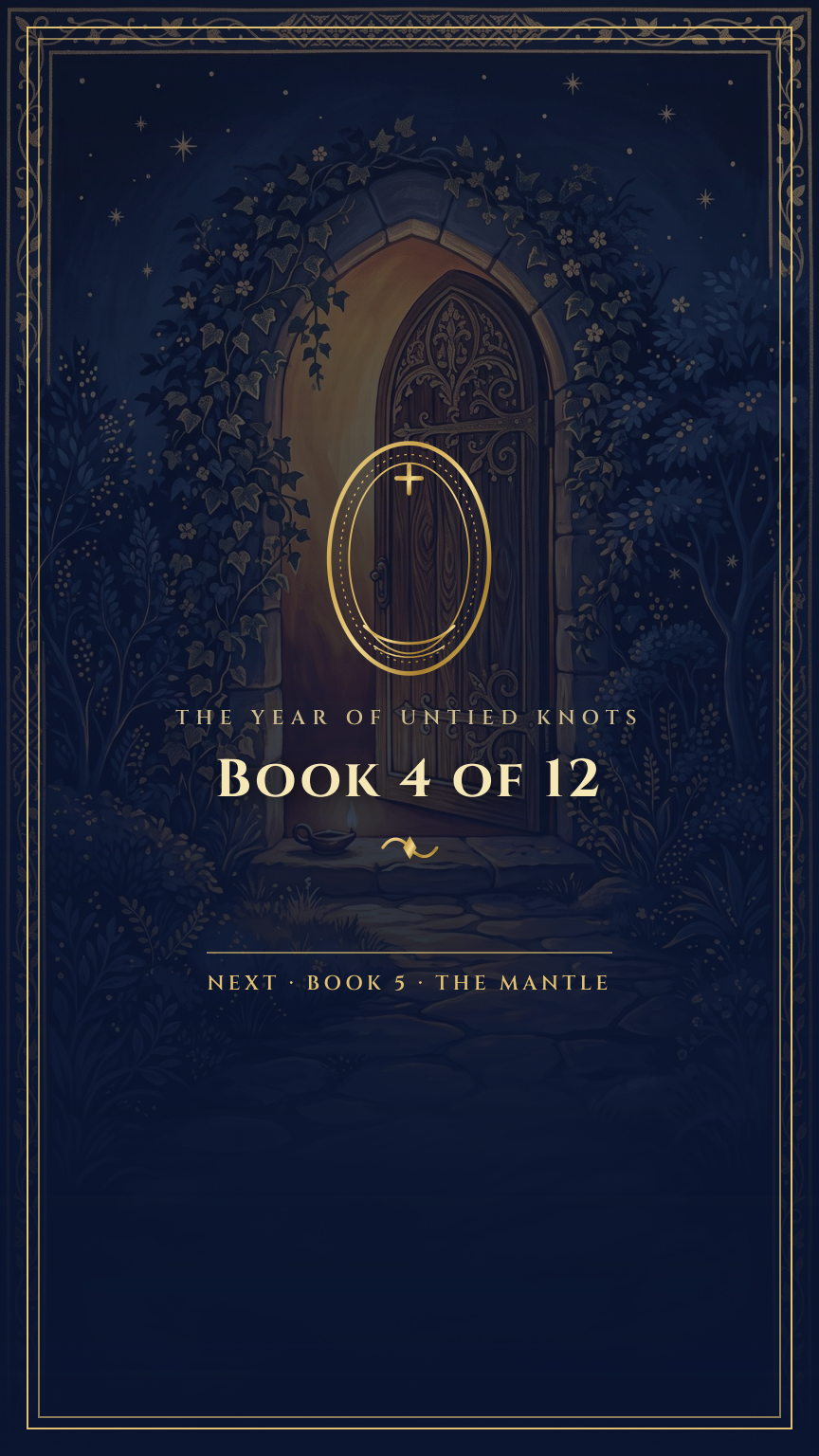
THE CANDLE OF THE MONTH: THE WELCOME

Light one candle by your front door, or on your table.

Say the names from your Names Page, slowly, one breath for each.

Blow it out with "Amen." The door stays open.

Turn to Book 5 tomorrow.



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 4 of 12

NEXT · BOOK 5 · THE MANTLE